CHAPTER VII

The Years Behind a Smile

Kolkata · October 2023

“How little we know of the lives that reach us already half-written. We meet someone in the middle of an ordinary afternoon, hear them laugh, learn the familiar habits of their days, and begin to mistake these small discoveries for understanding. Yet there are years behind every smile, names we have never heard, and sorrows that have learned to live quietly beside happiness. Perhaps knowing someone begins not when they tell us their story, but when we realise how much of it was lived before we arrived.”

Utkarsh arrived late enough to be noticed, but early enough to defend himself.

It was the ninth of October. The rain walk belonged to the previous week. This Monday began with Sanondita waiting in her usual place and Utkarsh arriving at precisely the hour when punctuality became a matter of argument.

He was seldom late for the lesson. It was merely the minutes before it that he seemed unwilling to honour.

She looked up from her phone, watched him approach, and returned to the screen with an expression that suggested she had expected nothing better.

“Good morning,” he said, setting down his bag.

“Is it?”

He glanced towards the entrance. “Looks like it.”

“For you, perhaps.”

He pulled out his chair. “What happened?”

“Nothing. I’ve just been sitting here.”

“That’s generally what people do in classrooms.”

She turned towards him. “Do you know how long I’ve been waiting?”

“No, but I have a feeling you’re about to tell me.”

“Twenty minutes.”

“That’s unfortunate.”

“Utkarsh.”

“What?”

“Could you come a little earlier for once?”

He considered this with an appearance of seriousness. “I could.”

She waited. “But?”

“Then you’d have to find something else to complain about.”

She stared at him before looking away, smiling despite herself.

“Unbelievable.”

He sat down, quietly pleased. Once he had been anxious to arrive early enough to find a place beside her. Now she expected him to appear and objected when he left too little time before the teacher arrived. He enjoyed the complaints more than he admitted. She disliked sitting alone while the room filled, particularly when the vacant chair invited someone else to settle there. With him, she could speak or remain on her phone without having to account for either choice.

“Show me what you’re watching,” he said.

She angled the phone away. “Nothing.”

“Then why are you hiding it?”

“Because you’ll start commenting.”

“I have excellent observations.”

“You have unnecessary observations.”

“Those are often the best kind.”

She turned the screen towards him. A man in an immaculate suit was delivering relationship advice with the gravity of someone addressing a national emergency. A woman, he explained, should

never tolerate a man who failed to answer her messages within five minutes.

Utkarsh watched until the man had established five minutes as a moral boundary.

“Does he have a job?”

Sanondita laughed. “Why?”

“What sort of employment lets you check your phone every five minutes?”

“Maybe that’s his job.”

“Then he’s very committed.”

She scrolled. The next young man was explaining how to recognise a toxic person. Replying quickly was desperate; replying slowly was manipulative. Asking questions was controlling. Failing to ask them was emotionally unavailable.

“So the safest relationship,” Utkarsh said, “is with someone who doesn’t exist.”

“That’s probably what he wants.”

“He’ll be very happy when everyone stops speaking to each other.”

She turned the volume down as her laughter threatened to become audible across the room. They watched another video.

Utkarsh might not have found it particularly funny on his own, but Sanondita looked at him just as he was preparing a remark, and he lost the ability to deliver it.

“Stop looking at me.”

“I’m not doing anything.”

“That’s the problem.”

She looked away, laughing harder. Students were arriving around them. Bags landed on writing tablets, chairs scraped, and someone described an incident on a local train with an enthusiasm that suggested the experience itself had been less entertaining.

A little farther along the front sat one of the more capable students in their batch. He usually wore a cap, even indoors, and adjusted the brim whenever anyone addressed him. That morning

he had removed it. Sanondita noticed him studying his reflection in the dark screen of his phone and nudged Utkarsh.

The young man examined the cap, smoothed its front, and put it on again.

“What?” Utkarsh whispered.

“Look at his expression.”

He looked. The student was still studying himself with the concentration of someone preparing for a portrait that would hang in a government office.

“He looks like he’s about to announce an important policy.”

Sanondita lowered her head. “Stop.”

“Any moment now, he’ll address the nation.”

The student adjusted the brim once more.

“The nation is waiting,” Utkarsh added.

That finished her. She bent over her notebook while he attempted an expression of academic concern. Neither managed particularly well.

Their humour was not always charitable. Once, another student had made a wonderfully theatrical gesture while telling a story, and they had caught each other’s eyes at the wrong moment. Utkarsh still remembered trying not to laugh. He also remembered the brief discomfort of watching the boy continue, unaware that he had become part of their amusement. Remembering that had not made either of them sensible every time somebody did something ridiculous.

Sanondita was particularly dangerous once silence became necessary. She could compose her face, look towards the front, and then glance sideways with such deliberate innocence that Utkarsh knew she was doing it for his benefit. He would look away, recover, and make the mistake of looking back.

“Look who’s here,” he murmured after a while.

Ujjawal had entered. He was serious about his preparation and had already cleared the first tier of some government recruitment examinations. Utkarsh knew him mostly by sight and reputation.

He also knew Ujjawal liked Sanondita, a piece of information that had supplied him with more material for teasing than cause for concern.

“There’s your future husband.”

She turned. “What?”

“Ujjawal.”

“Shut up.”

“Why? I’m giving you excellent advice.”

“I didn’t ask for advice.”

“That’s why it’s free.”

She shook her head, but he had adopted the thoughtful manner of someone considering a promising investment.

“Good at studies, serious about his career, already clearing examinations. Give him some time and he’ll probably have a government job.”

“So?”

“Marry him. Your life will be set.”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“I don’t like him.”

“A very small objection considering the benefits.”

“Utkarsh!”

“I’m thinking about your future.”

“Then stop.”

He smiled. “At least tell me what’s wrong with him.”

She hesitated. “His face is too round.”

He looked at her, uncertain for a moment whether he had heard correctly.

“His face?”

“Yes. I don’t like it.”

He glanced towards Ujjawal and back. “As if your face is particularly long and sharp.”

“Excuse me?”

“You’re rejecting him for having a round face as though yours was designed with a ruler.”

She struck his arm lightly with the back of her hand. “Idiot.”

He laughed. “Fine. I’ll inform him that his qualifications were excellent but his face failed the interview.”

“Utkarsh, stop!”

She was laughing now. He raised both hands.

“All right. The matter is closed.”

“Good.”

He waited a few seconds. “Very unfortunate for him, though.”

She turned towards him again, and he immediately found something else to look at.

He could recommend Ujjawal with complete confidence because he expected her to refuse. The joke cost him nothing. Had she shown interest, he suspected his enthusiasm for her future might have become less generous. For now, she was laughing beside him, and the unfortunate candidate had opened his notebook without any knowledge of the proceedings.

Sanondita returned to her phone. Another adviser was recommending a spouse who never argued.

“Easy,” Utkarsh said. “Marry someone who doesn’t speak.”

She looked at him. “How have you survived this long?”

“Pure determination.”

“Unfortunately.”

He was still smiling when the faculty member appeared.

Sanondita locked her phone. Utkarsh reached for his notebook so quickly that he almost knocked his pen to the floor.

“Very dedicated,” she whispered.

“Always.”

“You were watching reels two seconds ago.”

“Now I’m a different person.”

She pressed her lips together. The teacher arranged his papers, and conversation subsided. For a few moments they were as serious as everyone else. Then she leaned towards him.

He faced the board, still smiling. In August, he had wondered whether she might ever notice his empty chair. Now she complained when he left it empty for too long.

He picked up his pen. For once, he remained serious for nearly five minutes.

The morning's laughter merely became less convenient when the lesson began. Sanondita stopped writing and pressed the end of her pen against her lips. Two rows away, a student was listening with an expression of such disappointment that the teacher might have announced the cancellation of every pleasant thing in life. Utkarsh looked back at her. She was already watching him.

He lowered his head to examine his notes. The page contained a date and half a sentence.

"Don't," he whispered.

"I didn't say anything."

"You don't have to."

They recovered. The teacher explained a question and asked whether everyone understood. Utkarsh joined the collective assurance that they did. Beside him, Sanondita looked at his unfinished calculation.

"You didn't get that," she said quietly.

"I said yes."

"I heard you."

He glanced at her. She was waiting, her pen resting near the step he had missed. He showed her where he had lost the explanation.

She pointed back to the preceding line, and he saw what he had done.

He had learned to recognise the look she gave a doubtful answer.

She, apparently, had learned to recognise his. It was inconvenient to discover that familiarity worked in both directions, particularly during Arithmetic.

When the class paused, she closed her notebook and stretched her fingers.

He began putting his pen away. She had become accustomed to his uneven punctuality; her own attendance supplied a different puzzle. Over the preceding weeks, he had noticed that Fridays were less dependable than other days. Sometimes she mentioned work at home or an engagement. Often he did not ask.

He knew her elder sister worked in nursing. Perhaps Friday was a day they could spend together. Perhaps it had nothing to do with her sister. He looked towards Sanondita while considering this and was caught before he remembered to look away.

"Why do you keep looking at me?"

"I'm not."

"You were."

"I was thinking."

"About?"

"Whether you'll come on Friday."

"I don't know yet."

"See? You and Fridays have some arrangement."

She laughed. "What arrangement?"

"That's what I'm trying to find out."

"Maybe I just don't feel like coming."

"An excellent arrangement, then."

She shook her head and reached for her bag. He let the subject rest. He could remember an absence without requiring her to explain it.

His thoughts returned to the weeks before that Monday, when their conversations had begun reaching beyond coaching more often. They spoke about places, their families, and the inconveniences of travelling across the city. Sanondita sometimes mentioned the students she taught.

He learned about children he had never met through the questions they asked her and the answers they invented when she asked something in return.

Once she described a student who had confidently supplied an answer rather than admit he did not know it.

“Not a bad strategy,” Utkarsh said.

“It is when the answer makes no sense.”

“Confidence is important.”

“Then you should teach him.”

“I’d encourage him.”

“That’s exactly why you shouldn’t.”

He laughed. Later he thought about the hours in which she was the person explaining something, waiting for an answer, correcting a mistake. Her students knew habits of hers that he did not. Her sister knew others. He heard about their days in fragments, usually because something had annoyed or amused her enough to mention.

The photograph in July had already shown him how little he knew of her life beyond the classroom. He remembered the stranger on the motorcycle and the uncomfortable possibilities he had built around him. These conversations gave that distance a less alarming shape: lessons to prepare, people to visit, things that occupied her while he was doing something else. Sometimes he forgot a detail; sometimes it returned when she continued the story another day.

Then, during a conversation about their families and the work people did, he asked about her father.

It was an ordinary question. He expected a business, an office, a profession. Sanondita told him her father had passed away in 2017.

Utkarsh remained turned towards her. The answer he had been preparing no longer belonged in the conversation.

“I’m sorry,” he said.

She acknowledged it gently. He met her eyes longer than he usually managed. For once, he did not notice himself doing it.

It had happened when she was in Class Ten, around her board examinations. Her Mathematics paper had been approaching. Her father had gone to sleep one night and had not awakened the following morning. A heart attack.

Utkarsh listened. The examination stayed in his mind: a date on a timetable, a subject to revise, the ordinary expectation that the people at home would still be there when the paper was finished.

He remembered how much importance his own household had given those examinations. He could not imagine having to open a textbook after such a morning.

He did not say that he understood. He did not know who had helped her through the remaining papers, or what she remembered of them now. There were questions he might have asked, but she was speaking, and for once he was occupied entirely with hearing what she chose to tell him.

After a while, she changed the subject. He followed. Soon she made an observation about someone in class, he answered, and she smiled. He had no reason to hold her in a conversation she had finished merely because he was still trying to take it in.

On the journey home that day, he returned to the detail about Mathematics. He had known she graduated in 2022. Between that achievement and the morning she described were years he could list only in outline: school, college, the interruptions of the pandemic.

He had asked what she studied in July and been pleased to receive an answer. He had not known what had preceded it.

The discovery changed the depth of what he did not know. An unfamiliar face in a photograph had once been enough to disturb him. Now there was a girl sitting down to a board examination after losing her father, and he could not picture her clearly enough even to imagine what that required. Sanondita had told him what happened. She had not told him how every day afterward had felt.

His phone vibrated. A friend had sent a question so foolish that he stared at it, then laughed and typed a reply. A few moments later, he remembered her words again. He could be amused by a message and still be thinking of what she had said. Perhaps he should not have been surprised that she could speak about her father and later laugh at something in class. He let the two memories remain together.

Another of those earlier developments had been their connection on social media, before the eighth of October. Utkarsh had found Sanondita's Instagram profile some time earlier, just as he had once known her name before asking it. A familiar face in a friend's account, a suggested profile, one name leading to another: the internet was efficient at making introductions nobody had requested. It had been considerably less helpful with teaching him how to speak to her.

He had not followed the account. He preferred asking her himself, partly because a request could sit unanswered while a question asked beside her might become a conversation. There was no nobler explanation. He liked the few seconds in which she turned towards him to answer.

During an interval between classes, he asked for her Instagram ID.

"Why?"

"To follow you. What else?"

She told him. He typed the name, taking care not to appear quite as familiar with it as he was.

"Found you."

"Congratulations."

He smiled and sent the request. It was a small achievement for someone who already knew where to look. Still, she had given him the name herself. He could now appear among her notifications without privately accounting for how he had arrived there.

He had encountered her Facebook profile before as well. This time he sent a friend request. When it was accepted, he found photographs with school friends, birthday wishes, comments beneath old posts: the accumulation of small memories people left where they could be found again.

Sanondita looked younger in some of the pictures. There were uniforms, celebrations, outings, faces that appeared across several years. In one photograph she was smiling at something beyond the camera. He wondered what had happened just before it was taken.

Somebody might have made a joke. The photographer might simply have asked them to move together.

He could see the smile. The afternoon around it belonged to other people.

He scrolled farther. Some friends supplied compliments. Others treated compliments as a breach of friendship and offered insults that had evidently taken years to perfect. One name appeared often enough to become familiar: Nayan.

He teased her beneath several photographs. She sometimes replied in the same spirit. Utkarsh smiled at their exchanges; he understood friendships in which affection was demonstrated chiefly by refusing to say anything affectionate. He noticed an earlier birthday wish for Nayan and gathered that they had been friends at school. The name acquired a face, then a place among the people he recognised without knowing.

He lingered over the photographs. After what she had told him about her father, he found himself wondering about the days around each one. There were birthdays and school functions, ridiculous poses, a face caught laughing. He could not recover a life by putting its pictures in order. The dates gave him years; they did not tell him what it had been like to live them.

In one image, she was laughing in a way he recognised. He tried to imagine the sound. Somewhere, that day, he must have been occupied with his own friends or classes, without knowing there was a person whose laughter he would later recognise from a photograph.

He put down the phone. A little later, he picked it up to read the comments. Nayan had written something teasing; her reply was so like the things she said in class that Utkarsh could almost hear it. He laughed, closed Facebook, and returned to his work. For the moment, Nayan remained a school friend whose jokes happened to have survived online.

On the eighth of October, Sanondita posted photographs from an outing. Utkarsh saw them while scrolling through his phone. There

was water, open ground, vegetation beyond it. He could not identify the place. Kolkata was still a collection of familiar routes with a considerable amount of unknown city between them; people who had grown up there appeared to possess an unfair advantage.

He could search for the location. Instead, he decided to ask her when they met. It would give them something to discuss beyond examinations, and he wanted to hear whether the place was as pleasant as it looked. He went through the photographs once more.

She seemed happy. He put the phone away with the question in mind.

Back in the classroom on Monday, the ninth, he remembered the photographs during the break.

"Where did you go yesterday?"

Sanondita looked at him. "Yesterday?"

"Yes. I saw your photos."

"Oh. Bortir Bill."

"Where's that?"

"Barasat."

He repeated the name, trying to place it among the routes he knew.

"Is it far?"

She explained a little about the place. He listened and asked another question. For a while, it was the conversation he had intended: she had visited somewhere unfamiliar to him and was telling him about it. Then he thought of asking who had accompanied her.

He had asked friends that question without once considering how to say it. With Sanondita, he became aware of each word before he spoke.

"With whom?"

His voice was quieter than he intended. She paused. It could have been no more than the small interval before anyone answered a question; he noticed it all the same.

"Nayan."

He recognised the name at once. The birthday wish, the comments, the face among her school friends: details he had encountered separately assembled themselves around a person who had spent yesterday with her.

Until then, Nayan had belonged to old photographs. Now he belonged to an afternoon Utkarsh had spent elsewhere. He found himself remembering how happy she looked in the pictures, and disliked the small alteration in what that happiness made him feel.

Tanisha had once told him, as far as she knew, that Sanondita had never had a boyfriend. Utkarsh had never heard Sanondita mention being in a relationship, but that was hardly proof of anything.

Going somewhere with a school friend gave him no reason to assume there was one.

He could ask whether she would recommend the place. He could admit that he still had very little idea where it was. Instead, he looked at her and asked the question he had already begun to regret.

“Is this guy your boyfriend?”

He spoke carefully, as though care could keep the question from revealing why he wanted an answer.

Sanondita replied at once.

“Just because a girl goes somewhere with a boy doesn’t mean he’s her boyfriend.”

“Yeah. I know.”

He gave a small, embarrassed smile. He did know. That was the unfortunate part: he had known before asking.

For a moment he searched for a joke. Earlier that morning, he had recommended Ujjawal as her future husband without difficulty.

He could not find anything equally amusing to say about Nayan.

With Ujjawal, he knew where the joke would end. Here he knew almost nothing, and the little he did know had made him jealous.

There it was. A word less comfortable than curiosity, but closer to what had happened. He did not want her to have enjoyed the

outing any less. He wanted, rather painfully, to have been the person beside her.

Sanondita had corrected his assumption. He did not turn her correction into another question. The conversation moved on, though he remained half occupied with the one they had left behind.

His next remark arrived a little late. She answered it, and he made himself listen.

She seemed untroubled. He was grateful for that, then faintly embarrassed by how much relief he took from something as ordinary as her continuing to speak to him. He could have spared himself the difficulty by asking about the scenery.

By the time the class ended, he had stopped looking for a way to repair a conversation she did not appear to consider broken.

Sanondita was putting her things away, occasionally pausing to answer someone who came over to ask about the lesson. Beside her, Utkarsh searched his bag for a pen he was almost certain he had already put inside it.

“You’ve lost something again?” she asked.

“No.”

“Then what are you looking for?”

“My pen.”

“So you’ve lost your pen.”

“I haven’t lost it. I just don’t know where it is.”

She laughed. “That’s a very important difference.”

“Thank you for understanding.”

“I don’t.”

He found the pen beneath his notebook.

“There. See?”

“Congratulations. Again.”

He looked at her. “You’ve become very generous with congratulations lately.”

“Someone has to encourage you.”

He slipped the pen into his bag, smiling. She had caught him searching before he had thought to ask for help. It was a small thing to know about someone: that his missing possessions generally remained within reach, that an explanation would follow their recovery. She knew it well enough to begin teasing before he found the pen.

He wondered whether she would remember his other question as clearly. Perhaps she had noticed his hesitation. Perhaps she would mention it to a friend. He could almost hear her telling the story, supplying his careful tone while somebody else laughed. He hoped she would at least include the part where he had realised he was being foolish. Unfortunately, most of that part had occurred inside his head.

They left with the other students. The coaching centre filled with the familiar disorder that followed a lesson: people comparing answers, someone calling to a friend halfway down the corridor, phones ringing after a morning of being ignored. Utkarsh walked beside Sanondita while she complained about one of the questions.

He suggested that it had probably been reasonable before the faculty member decided to explain it.

“You understood it?” she asked.

“Eventually.”

“Then why were you looking so confused?”

“That’s my face when I’m concentrating.”

“Your face always looks like that.”

He turned towards her. “That’s unnecessarily personal.”

She laughed. He joined her before thinking of an answer. There was no need to be impressive beside her just then; he could fail to defend himself and still enjoy the conversation. He had spent a considerable part of the day demonstrating this.

Near the entrance, she checked her phone. He waited while she finished reading, then they exchanged their usual goodbye. For a moment he watched her leave before turning towards his own route.

Usually, he carried away a remark of hers to laugh at again, or something he had forgotten to ask. Today Nayan's name returned as well. Sanondita had visited a place with a school friend. The fact was small enough to fit into a sentence; his mind kept finding room around it.

Perhaps they had arranged the outing with a message and a convenient day. Perhaps they had talked about people from school, using names that required no explanation. Utkarsh imagined how little effort it might take to ask her to go somewhere when there was already so much friendship behind the question. He thought of the care with which he had found a reason to go shopping with her. He had enjoyed every minute of that afternoon. Remembering how carefully it had begun made the ease he imagined between them hurt a little.

He knew none of the details. Nayan might have been as difficult to make plans with as any of his own friends. The effortless afternoon existed mostly in Utkarsh's head, where other people's conversations had an unfair advantage over his own.

At least he recognised that much. In July, the unfamiliar boy on the motorcycle had left him searching for an explanation. Now he had a name and some history, and still wanted more certainty than either could provide. Knowing more about Sanondita had not cured his ability to make himself uneasy. It had, however, made it harder to forget that the people in her photographs were people she knew, with years of friendship behind them, rather than questions placed there for him to solve.

He thought of his own school friends, most of whom Sanondita had never met. An evening with them would not make him any less pleased to see her the next day. He would have understood that immediately if someone else had asked.

But he was not someone else.

He loved her.

He had known it for some time. It was easier to think about getting a seat beside her, making her laugh, remembering something she wanted. Each small wish could be met or disappointed on its own. The larger one remained difficult even to name, because he could do so little about whether she would ever share it.

He had not told her. He could not know what she had guessed, if anything, from the attention he gave her. She knew the version of him who arrived late, argued about misplaced pens, and made her laugh when they were supposed to be listening. He liked being that person with her. He wanted more, and had hoped—without quite admitting it—that wanting it patiently might somehow make it happen.

Her reply had brought him back to what she had actually said.

She had gone somewhere with a friend. He had asked a question whose answer mattered to him for reasons he had kept to himself.

She could not be expected to answer those unspoken reasons too.

By the time he reached the station, his embarrassment had lost its first sharpness. He took out his phone and thought of opening the photographs again. He knew what he would do: linger over details he had passed the night before, looking for reassurance in something that had never been posted to reassure him.

His thumb rested above the screen. Then he locked it and put the phone away.

The wish to look did not disappear. He walked with it for a while, among people occupied with their calls and journeys home.

Someone nearby laughed into a phone. He remembered Sanondita bent over her notebook, trying to keep quiet, and found himself smiling before the memory of his question could interfere.

He would see her again. There would be another lesson, something foolish to laugh about, perhaps another complaint about

his arrival. He could try arriving early tomorrow without finding an explanation for every afternoon she spent elsewhere.

He still wanted to hear her stories, including those about friends he had never met. But he wanted her to tell them because she wished to, not because he had made an ordinary outing sound like something she must defend.

That morning he had cheerfully recommended Ujjawal; by afternoon, another boy's name had unsettled him. He could not promise himself a better reaction every time. He could at least leave the photographs alone today.

She had been a whole person before he met her. She would remain one when he was not there. He was only beginning to learn how to love her without forgetting either truth.